used to: what Murphy does not tell you

Day 2 · Grammar beyond Murphy

Murphy first
Murphy red, Unit 36 (pages 82–83): the form, *didn't use to* and *did you use to*. Do **36.1, 36.2** in class, **36.3** at home.
This file adds five things the book does not explain.

1 · used to = a state or a habit in the past, not now

*I **used to live** in a village.* (now I do not) *We **used to play** outside every day.*
Use it for things that were **true for a long time** or **happened again and again**.

2 · NOT for one time, or for a number of times

✗ I ~~used to go~~ to Italy three times. → ✓ I **went** to Italy three times.
✗ Last night I ~~used to see~~ a ghost. → ✓ Last night I **saw** a ghost.
With a number (three times), a clear time (yesterday, in 2019) or a short time (for two weeks): past simple.

3 · Spelling and sound

Positive: **used to** (with -d). Negative and question: **use to** (without -d), because did / didn't already shows the past.
*I **used to** be afraid. I didn't **use to** like fish. Did you **use to** have a pet?*
Sound: /juːst tə/ — the "d" is not heard.

4 · Then and now

*I used to be afraid of the dark, **but now** I am not.*
*We used to live in a village, but we **don't any more**. / **no longer** live there.*
There used to be a cinema here. Now there is a shop.
This is the most useful pattern: compare the past and the present.

5 · The Russian trap

«Раньше я играл в футбол» → *I **used to play** football.* but «Вчера я играл в футбол» → *I **played** football yesterday.*
Russian uses the same «играл» for both. English chooses: a past habit → used to; one finished event → past simple.
Do not confuse with *I am used to* (я привык): that is a different grammar, we learn it later.

Practice

Day 2 · Practice 1

What to do: Exercises 1–2 in class, alone, then check. Exercise 3: the class translates aloud, one sentence each.

1 Used to or past simple? Choose

1. When I was small, I (used to be / was) afraid of the dark.
2. Last summer we (used to go / went) to Samarkand.
3. My grandfather (used to tell / told) us ghost stories every evening.
4. I (used to see / saw) a strange light in the sky last night.
5. We (used to live / lived) in a village for five years.
6. She (didn't use to like / didn't like) fish when she was a child.
7. He (used to have / had) a dog, but now he has a cat.
8. They (used to play / played) football on Sunday. They played three matches.

2 Then and now: finish the sentences with used to

1. I ____ (be) shy, but now I am very open.
2. There ____ (be) a park here, but now there is a supermarket.
3. My parents ____ (not / have) a car, but now they have two.
4. We ____ (watch) cartoons every Saturday, but now we don't.
5. Dilnoza ____ (live) in Bukhara, but now she lives in Tashkent.
6. ____ you ____ (play) the piano when you were a child?

3 Translate into English

1. Раньше я боялся темноты.

2. Мы жили в деревне, но теперь мы там не живём.

3. Здесь раньше был кинотеатр.

4. Вчера я видел странный свет.

5. Раньше он не любил рыбу.

6. Ты раньше играл в футбол?

7. Мы три раза были в горах.

Practice 2

Day 2 · Practice 2

What to do: Alone, then read your sentences aloud.

4 Ask a grandparent or an older person: five questions with “Did you use to…?”

Write the questions and the answers: *Did you use to walk to school? Yes, I did. We used to walk five kilometers.* Report one answer to the class.

5 Complete the story: used to or past simple

When I was a child, my family (1 live) _____ in a small village in the mountains. We (2 not / have) _____ electricity, so in the evening we (3 sit) _____ by the fire. My grandfather (4 tell) _____ us ghost stories. One night in 2010 a storm (5 come) _____ and the wind (6 break) _____ the window. We (7 be) _____ very afraid. We (8 not / go) _____ out for two days. Now we live in the city, and we (9 not / have) _____ a fire. But I (10 love) _____ those evenings.

Answers · Day 2 grammar

For the teacher

1 used to be · went · used to tell · saw · lived · didn’t like (or didn’t use to like) · used to have · played

2 used to be · used to be · didn’t use to have · used to watch · used to live · Did you use to play

3 I used to be afraid of the dark. · We used to live in a village, but we don’t live there now. · There used to be a cinema here. · Yesterday I saw a strange light. · He didn’t use to like fish. · Did you use to play football? · We went to the mountains three times.

4 Own answers.

5 lived (used to live) · didn’t have (didn’t use to have) · used to sit · used to tell · came · broke · were · didn’t go · don’t have · love